HIST 300: Indigenous Peoples of Canada to 1876

“White Sails on the Horizon: Contacts in the Atlantic World”

Week 2-2

Dr. Colin Osmond

Fall 2023



Recap:

- Several Theories on Peopling of Turtle Island
  - Creation Stories
  - Bering Land Bridge
  - Pacific Migration
  - The Problem with ‘X’
- Indigenous Knowledge denied as a means to Deny Land Rights
- Theory – an idea with evidence
  - How much? Where from? What about other evidence?

Learning Outcomes/Keyword

- L’nu social and political structures before contact
- L’nu Resource Extraction and subsistence
- Contact and Consequences
- Virgin Soil Epidemics
- “Doctrine of Discovery” as a mode of Erasure
- Islands of colonialisms on the edge of an Indigenous world
- *Keywords: Mi’kma’ki, Glooscap, Accommodation, Virgin Soils Epidemics, Columbian Exchange, Terra Nullius*

L’nu – “The People”

- Mi’kmaq/Mi’kmaw – “My Kin” or “my relations”
- “Mi’kma’ki” - Territory stretched over present-day Nova Scotia, Prince Edward Island, and parts of Newfoundland, New Brunswick, Quebec, and New England.

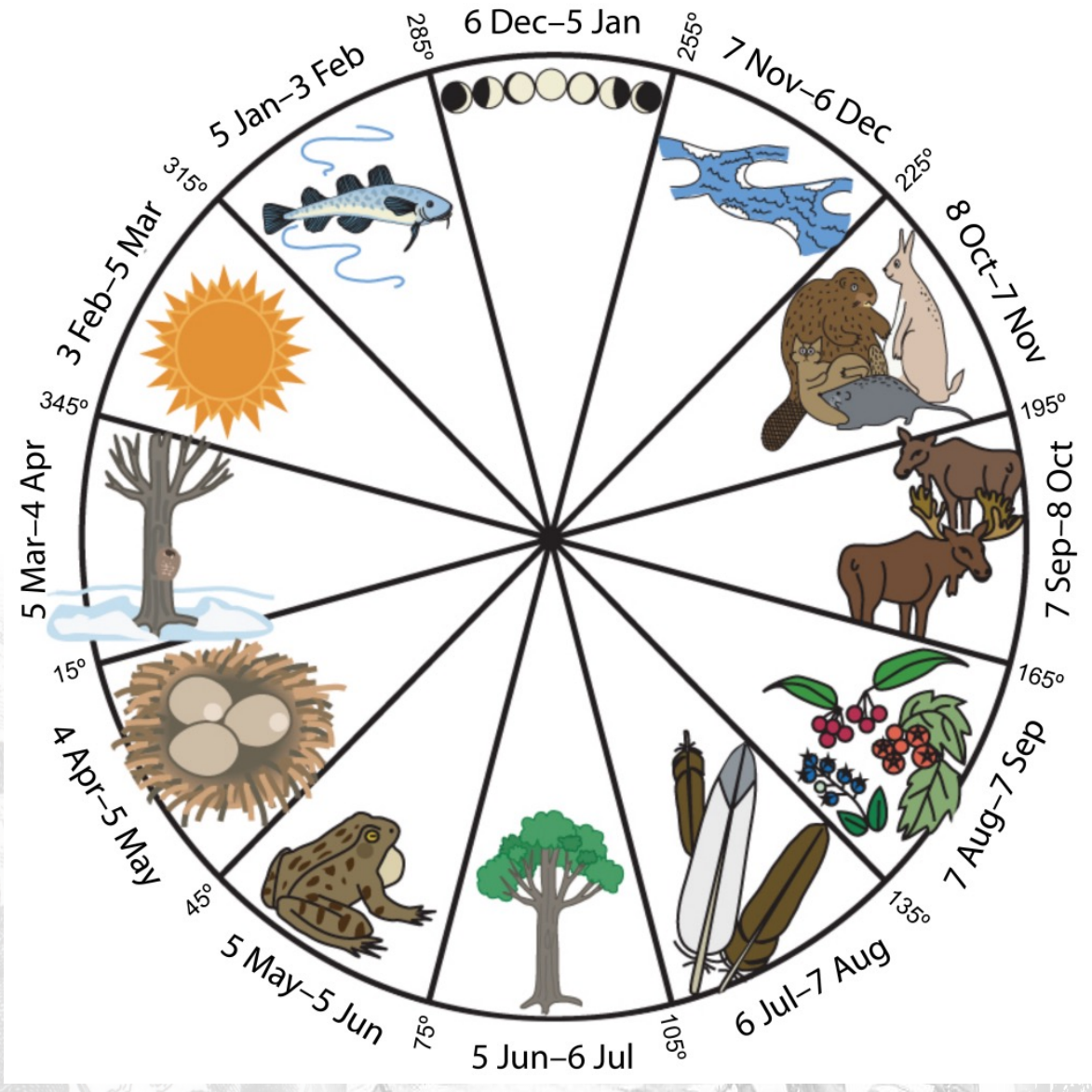




Mi’kmaq Creation Story

- Statue of Glooscap – Millbrook First Nation, Nova Scotia

L’nu Lifecycles and Systems



L’nu Governance and Political Structures

- Family – nuclear family unit – parents and children
- Village – connected groups of families, with a local leader or “Sakamow”, spiritual leader “Sa’ya”, and Keptins
- Kinship networks – extended connections between families and villages over space, based on interrelatedness
- District – resource gathering area made up of many villages and families
- Grand Council/Sante Mawi’omi – annual meeting between all districts and Sakamows

Warfare and the Wabanaki Confederacy

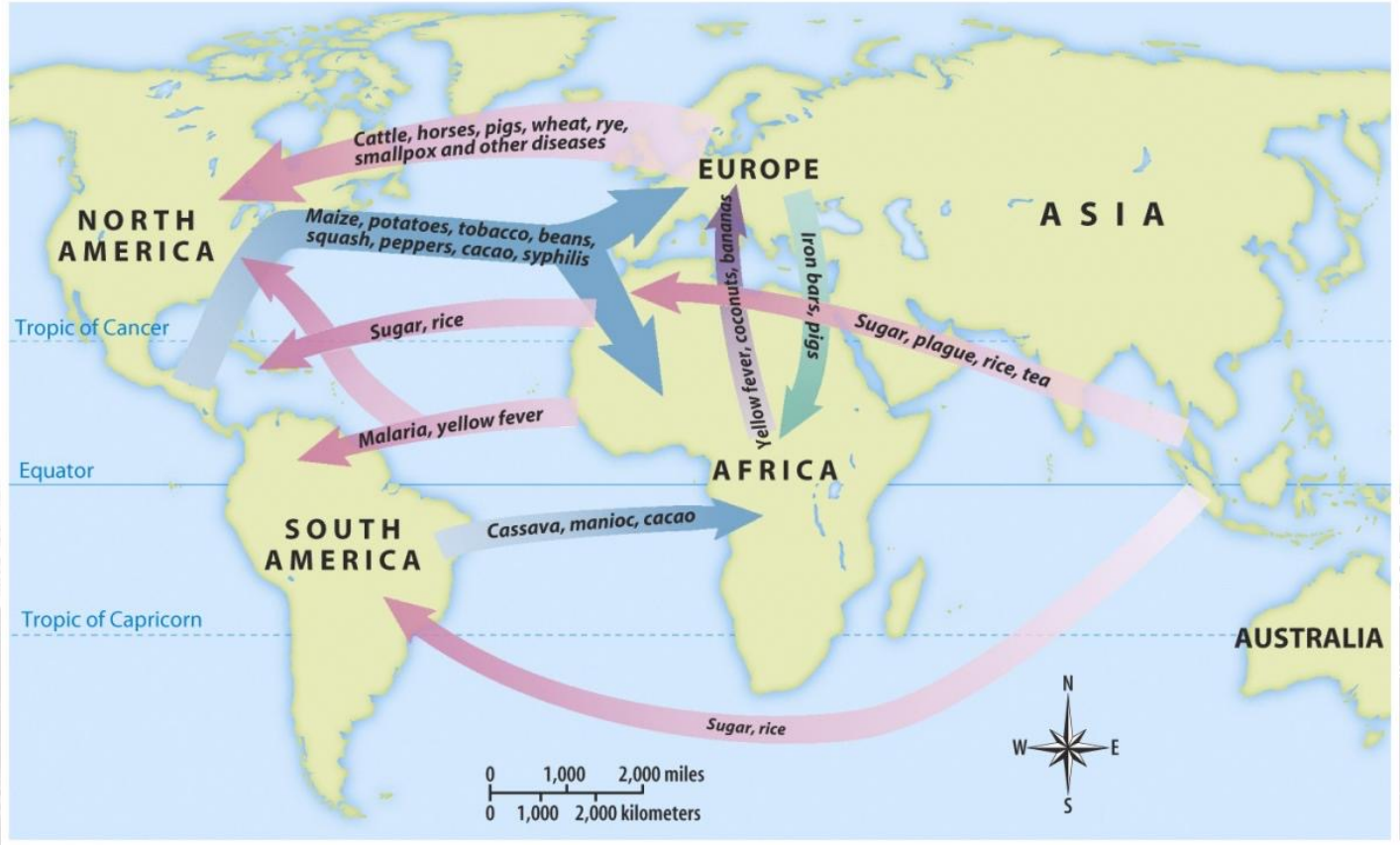
- Confederacy made up of the Mi'kmaq, Maliseet, Passamaquoddy, Penobscot, and the eastern Abenaki.
- Political and Military Alliance – formed to defend against Haudenosaunee raids.
- Likely formed in the 14th Century
- Existed in a dynamic and complex world or warfare and raiding (both ways)

Contacts and Consequences

- Norse Explorations circa 1000 AD
- Giovanni Caboto/John Cabot – 1497
  - Fishers had probably already visited what is now Atlantic Canada
- Jacques Cartier – 1534
- Basque Fishers – seasonal travel/fishing in 16th Century
- Mi'kmaq adjusted trade to tap into new markets
- Adoption of new agricultural crops/metal tools
- Copper Kettles
- Revamped fur trade economy

The Columbian Exchange

- Exchange of Goods, Foodstuffs, ideas, and germs after Contacts
  - To Europe from North/South America: Corn, beans, cocoa, squash, pumpkin, tomato, potato, bell peppers, peanuts, tobacco
  - To North/South America from Europe: Wheat, oats, livestock (cows, chickens, horses, sheep, etc.), metal goods



Virgin Soil Epidemics

- New pathogens (germs, diseases, viruses) introduced to a population with no prior biological immunity.
- Influenza, measles, whooping cough, typhus, dysentery, malaria
- Smallpox was most deadly
- 60-95% mortality rate
- Indigenous systems destroyed – governance collapsed, healing systems failed, villages depopulated, entire cultures extinct
- The Indigenous world was in chaos – this is what Europeans encountered over the next centuries
- The myth of the “Virgin” landscape

Mi’kmaw Responses

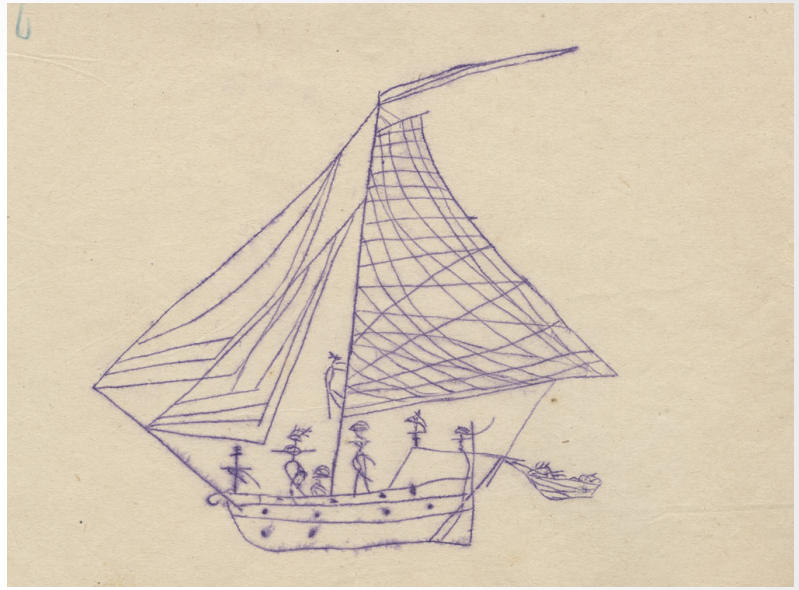
- Pre-contact population?
  - Issues with calculating numbers
  - Low Estimaes – 1300 in 1843, over 26,000 before 1600
  - Later Data – more than 50,000 on mainland Nova Scotia alone
  - Likely ~90% mortality (i.e. 9/10 died, 1/10 lived) over 16-19th C.
- Responses to Contact
  - Inland migrations
    - Fear of Europeans – diseases, fled coastline when they saw ships
  - Over time- increased focus on hunting and trapping to trade for metal goods, fabrics, copper kettles, etc.
  - Changes made actively by Mi’kmaq – not by coercion or force
  - Remaking of Mi’kmaq Economy to fit newcomers into their economic world



Mi’kmaw Trade camp, Tufts Cove (Halifax Harbour), 1791.

Activity – Mi’kmaq Petroglyphs

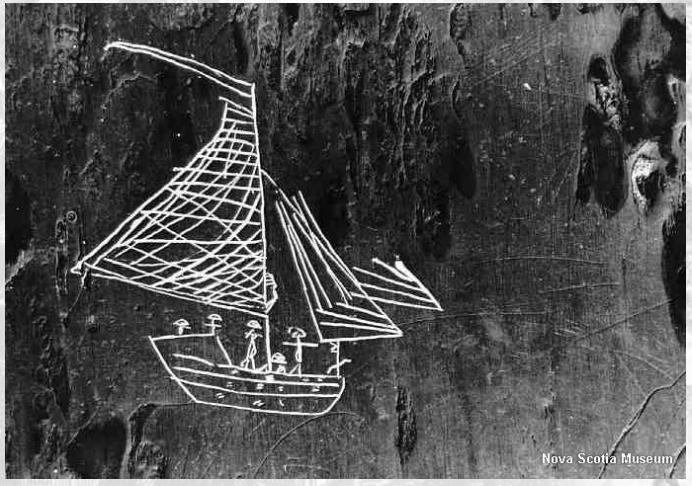


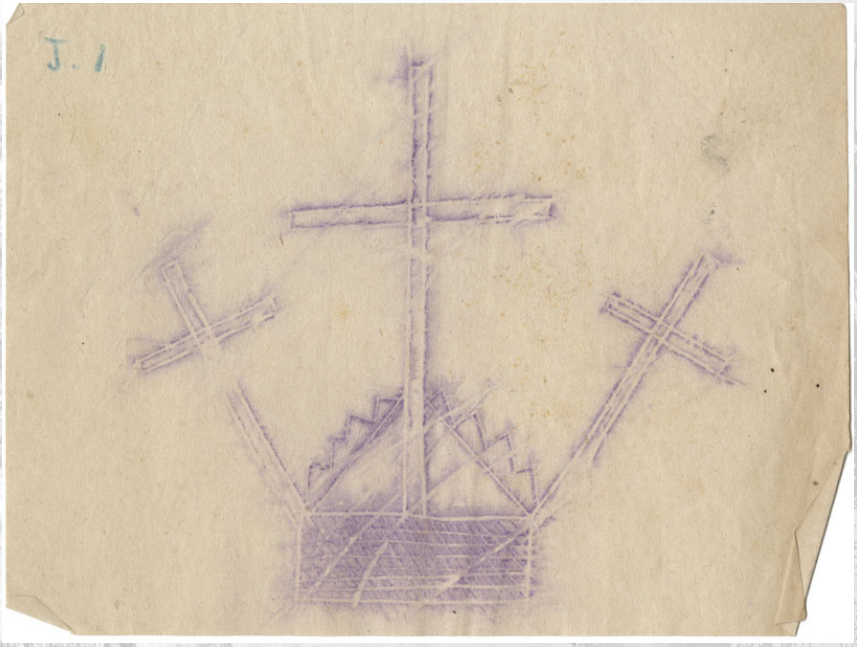


What do these petroglyphs tell us about Mi’kmaw perspectives of contact?

How can we use these sources as historical documents?

What do they teach us about Mi’kmaw history/historical consciousness?





Next Week:

Beothuk: Colonial Encounters in Ktaqmkuk - “Newfoundland”

- ***Read:*** William Gilbert, “Beothuk-European Contact in the 16th Century: A Re-evaluation of the Documentary Evidence”, *Acadiensis* Vol. xxxx, No. 1 (2011), 24-44.
- Belshaw: Pgs. 51-54

